

Storck Chocolate Price Increase Analysis: Cocoa Market & Cost Structure Assessment

1 Executive Summary

Storck's proposed 3–4% price increase has a legitimate cost basis but faces significant timing challenges that weaken its justification. Cocoa prices surged approximately 430% from a \$2,426/MT baseline in 2021 to a record \$12,906/MT in December 2024 [1], driven by West African supply collapses and speculative amplification. However, prices have since corrected 50–70% from those peaks, with the ICCO revising the 2024/25 balance to a 75,000-tonne surplus [2, 3]. At approximately \$3,392–\$3,883/MT in mid-2026, cocoa remains elevated above the long-term norm but is trending downward [4, 3].

The strongest argument in Storck's favor is that the increase is extraordinarily conservative relative to competitors—Mondelēz raised European prices approximately 30%, Hershey implemented low double-digit increases, and Lindt raised prices 15.8% in H1 2025 alone [5, 6, 7]. Beyond cocoa, Storck faces broad-based inflation: aluminum packaging up 47% [8], energy up 50–60% [9], labor up 18–22% [10], and transportation up 30–40% [11]. These cumulative pressures across the cost structure provide justification independent of cocoa alone.

The most compelling counterargument is timing: cocoa costs are declining, competitors like Mondelēz are actively considering price cuts [12], and 45% of consumers have already reduced chocolate purchases [13]. The recommended negotiation approach is to accept a reduced increase of 2–2.5% with a review clause tied to cocoa benchmarks, or defer the full increase to Q4 2026 when hedging positions will better reflect current lower spot prices—ensuring pricing reflects forward-looking costs rather than legacy peak-period procurement [14].

2 Cocoa Bean Price Development 2021–2026

The cocoa market experienced one of the most dramatic commodity price cycles in modern history between 2021 and 2026. From a stable baseline of approximately \$2,426/MT in 2021 [15], prices surged to an all-time high of \$12,906/MT on NY ICE futures in December 2024 [1] — a roughly 430% increase that far exceeded the previous record of \$5,104/MT set in 1977 [16].

Chart Explanation: The chart shows annual average cocoa prices alongside peak/notable levels for each year. Prices remained near the historical baseline of ~\$2,500/MT [17] through 2022, before escalating sharply from 2023 onward. The 2024 peak of \$12,906/MT [1] represents an extraordinary deviation, while 2026 shows the correction phase with prices still elevated above pre-crisis norms.

The Stable Baseline (2021–2022). Cocoa traded within a narrow band of \$1,756–\$2,943/MT from 2017 through early 2023 [16], consistent with the long-term norm of approximately \$2,500/MT that had prevailed since the 1980s [17]. The 2022 annual average of \$2,369/MT [15] gave no indication of the crisis ahead.

The Crisis (2023–2024). Prices began climbing in H2 2023, reaching \$4,200/MT by December [15], driven by the onset of severe West African supply disruptions. Ghana's production collapsed from a record 1.047 million MT in 2020/21 to approximately 600,000 MT — a decline exceeding 40% [18] — as Cocoa Swollen Shoot Virus Disease devastated nearly 500,000 hectares [19]. Simultaneously, extreme rainfall in December 2023 (more than double the 30-year average) caused black pod disease and crop rot [20]. The resulting 2023/24 global supply deficit reached a record 489,000 tonnes, with stocks-to-grindings ratios falling to a 45-year low [21, 22]. Hedge fund speculation amplified the spike, with trend-following funds driving London cocoa to record levels before their subsequent exit collapsed market liquidity [23].

The Correction (2025–2026). Prices began correcting in H2 2025, with London cocoa falling to approximately \$4,106/MT by October 2025 [24]. The correction accelerated in early 2026, reaching a low of \$2,846/MT in March [16] as Ivory Coast production recovered toward 2 million tonnes [16] and the ICCO revised the 2024/25 balance to a surplus of 48,000 tonnes [25]. However, renewed El Niño fears drove a rebound to \$5,247/MT by late June 2026 [1] — still approximately 115% above the 2021 baseline [1]. Forward estimates project prices of \$4,233/MT by end of Q3 2026 and \$3,530 within 12 months [1], though Citigroup warns prices could climb to \$5,000–\$6,000/MT if El Niño materializes [26].

3 Storck Pricing History and Industry Context

August Storck KG, founded in 1903 in Werther, Westphalia, is a privately held, family-owned German confectionery company — the second-largest in Germany by sales and 13th globally [24]. Owned by third-generation Axel Oberwelland, Storck employs over 5,000 people, sells in more than 100 countries, and generates approximately \$2 billion in annual revenue [27]. Key chocolate-containing brands include Merci, Toffifee, Knoppers, and Riesen [24], and the company also produces Moser-Roth chocolate for Aldi [28].

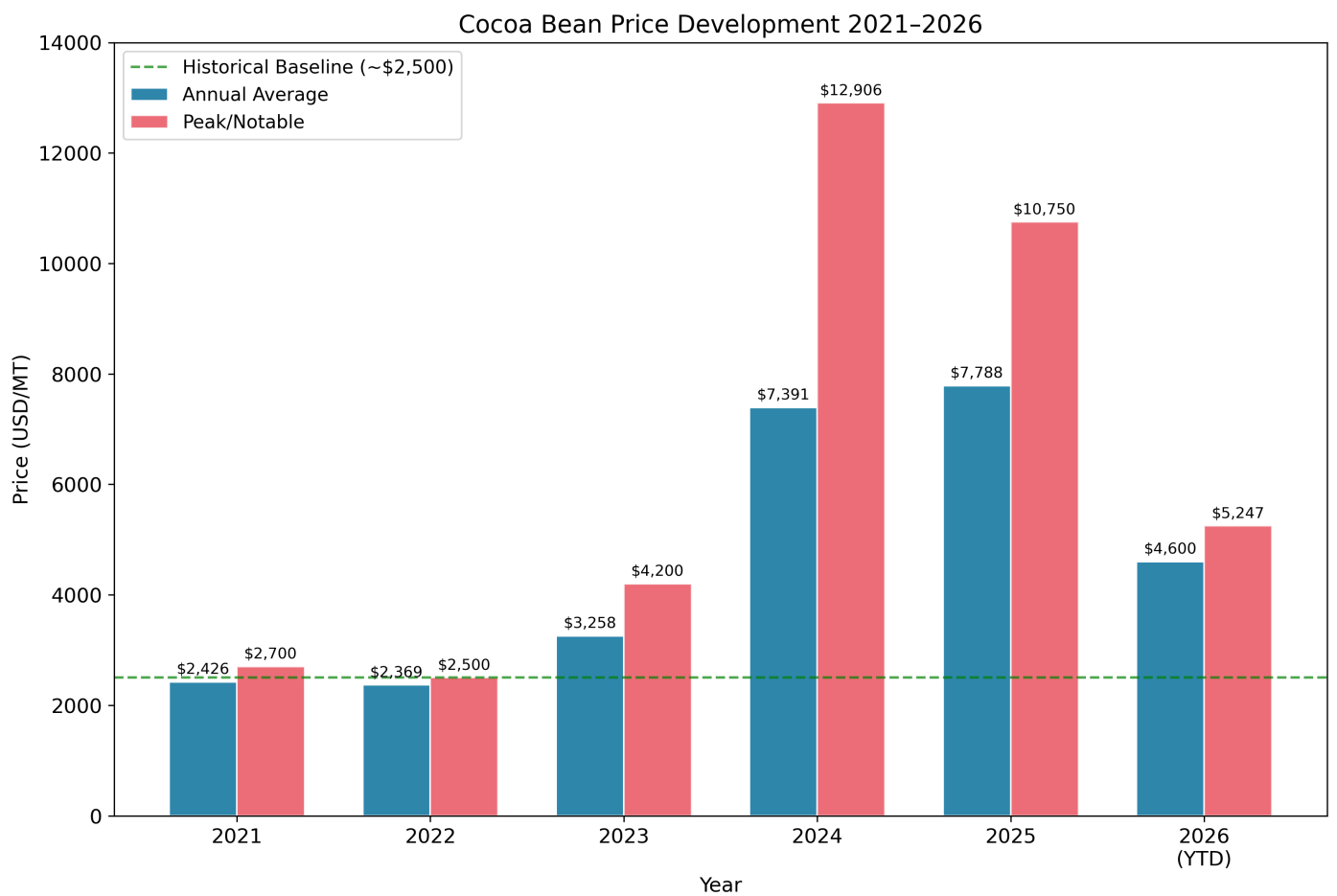


Figure 1: Cocoa Bean Price Development 2021-2026

Pricing Transparency. As a private company, Storck does not publish earnings reports or pricing announcements [24], making granular price adjustment data unavailable. However, the broader German confectionery market provides strong context. German chocolate bar consumer prices rose approximately 31.8% from the 2020 base year through 2024 [29], and by Christmas 2025, chocolate Santa Clauses cost up to 25% more than the prior year [30].

Industry-Wide Pass-Through Dynamics. The BDSI (Federal Association of the German Confectionery Industry), of which Storck is a member, reported “extreme upheavals and dramatic price increases” for raw materials as early as 2021 [31], with procurement prices for vegetable oils/fats, butter, and sugar more than doubling by 2022 versus August 2021 [32]. The association warned that cost explosions were “depriving companies of the liquidity and earnings that are indispensable for securing jobs” [32]. By January 2026, the BDSI reported that its ~200 member companies experienced financial strain from “drastic increases in ingredients” along with staff, energy, and administration costs [33].

Hedging Lag and Delayed Impact. According to RaboResearch, many manufacturer contracts were hedged in early 2024 before prices exploded, meaning the steepest retail price hikes were anticipated in H2 2024 and into 2025, with estimates of 30%+ retail increases [34]. J.P. Morgan strategist Tracey Allen confirmed in August 2025 that chocolatiers were still dealing with heightened cocoa prices from Q4 2024 records, with “higher prices for longer” being passed through to consumers [35].

Vertical Integration as Partial Buffer. Storck maintains some vertical integration: it processes cocoa beans at its Ohrdruf facility, operates its own cocoa farm in the Dominican Republic (1,530 hectares, 1.4 million cocoa plants since 2016), and runs a fermentation/drying centre in Ecuador [36]. While this provides some buffer, the company sources primarily from West Africa via certified supply chains — precisely where the crisis was most acute [36].

4 Manufacturing Cost Structure and Input Inflation

Chocolate manufacturing costs extend well beyond cocoa beans. For a mass-produced chocolate bar, ingredients account for approximately 60–70% of direct manufacturing cost [37], with packaging at 15–19%, and labor, energy, and transportation each contributing 4–5% [37]. Understanding how each component has inflated since 2021 reveals why Storck faces broad-based cost pressure — not a single-commodity issue.

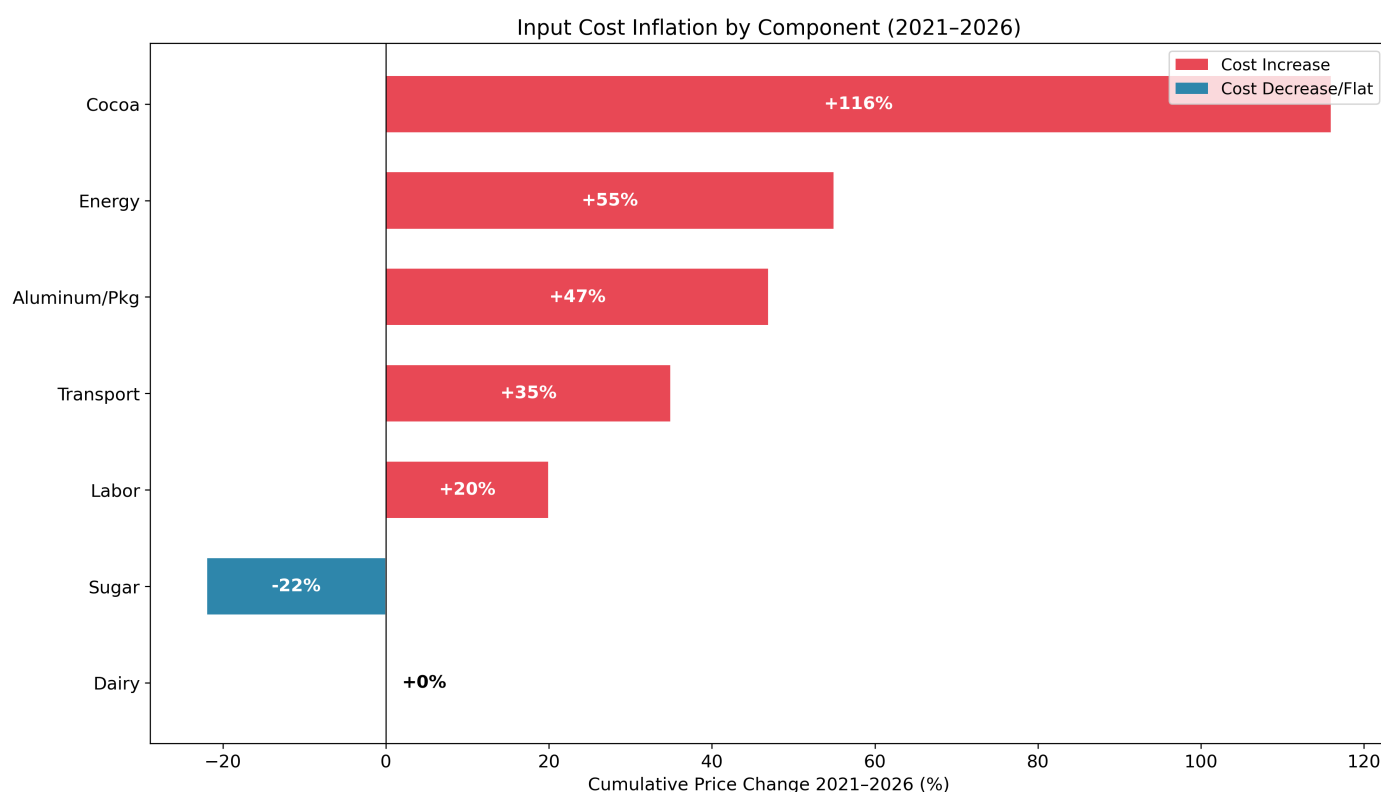


Figure 2: Input Cost Inflation by Component 2021-2026

Chart Explanation: The chart displays cumulative price changes for each major input from 2021 to mid-2026. Cocoa dominates at +116% [38], followed by energy (+50–60%) [39, 9], aluminum/packaging (+47%) [8], transportation (+30–40%) [11], and labor (+18–22%) [10]. Sugar (-22%) [40] and dairy (approximately flat) [41] partially offset these increases.

Cocoa — the dominant driver. Despite correcting from its 2024 peak, cocoa remains at approximately \$5,247/MT in mid-2026, still 116% above the 2021 average of \$2,426/MT [38]. Sugar constitutes at least 50% of a mass-produced bar by weight, but cocoa components (butter, solids, liquor) drive the cost premium [37].

Packaging materials. Aluminum — critical for foil wrapping — surged from \$2,477/MT in 2021 to \$3,654/MT by May 2026, a 47% increase with a 49% year-on-year spike [8, 42]. European pulp and paper manufacturers also face persistent cost headwinds from energy, logistics, and chemical inputs [43].

Energy. European natural gas (Dutch TTF) is projected to average €47.7/MWh in 2026, approximately 30% above 2025 levels and roughly 50–60% above pre-crisis 2021 levels [9]. UK energy bills in July 2026 remain 53% above winter 2021/22 levels [44].

Labor and transportation. Euro area hourly labor costs increased 3.2% year-on-year in Q1 2026 [10], with cumulative inflation of approximately 18–22% since 2021. European road freight contract rates reached an index of 140.1 in Q1 2026, representing a 30–40% increase from 2021 levels [11].

Offsetting factors. Sugar prices have declined approximately 22% from 2021, trading at around 14 ct/lb in mid-2026 versus 17.86 ct/lb in 2021 [40]. Dairy (whole milk powder) is roughly flat at \$3,589/MT, having peaked in 2022 and subsequently declined [41].

Cost Component	% of Production Cost	2021→2026 Change
Cocoa (beans/butter)	20–25%	+116% [38]
Sugar	15–20%	-22% [40]
Dairy (milk powder)	5–10%	~Flat [41]
Packaging (aluminum)	15–19%	+47% [8]
Labor	4–5%	+18–22% [10]
Energy & overhead	4–8%	+50–60% [9]
Transportation	4–5%	+30–40% [11]

Table 1: Input Cost Inflation Summary 2021–2026

The net effect is substantial: while sugar and dairy provide modest relief, the combined inflation across cocoa, packaging, energy, labor, and transport far outweighs these offsets.

5 Competitive Benchmarking

Storck’ s proposed 3–4% increase is remarkably modest when measured against the pricing actions taken by every major competitor over the same period. The U.S. Producer Price Index for chocolate and confectionery manufacturing rose approximately 67% from December 2021 to December 2025, with the sharpest annual spike of +32.3% occurring in 2024 during the cocoa crisis [45].

Chart Explanation: Storck’ s proposed 3–4% increase is compared against actual cumulative price increases by major competitors. Nestlé raised prices approximately 8–10% annually across 2022–2023 [46, 47, 48]. Mars increased variety pack prices by ~12% [49]. Lindt raised prices 15.8% in H1 2025 alone [7]. Hershey implemented cumulative increases of ~20% [50, 51]. Mondelez raised European prices by 12.6% in Q3 2025, with effective increases on products like Milka reaching 34% when combined with shrinkflation [52, 53].

Headline price increases. Hershey implemented a 17% increase on king-size and single-size packs in June 2022, followed by a further low double-digit increase (13–20%) effective fall 2025 [50, 51]. Mondelez raised prices by more than 8% in January 2024 on top of prior 2023 increases [54]. The average U.S. candy bar unit price increased 41% from \$2.43 in July 2021 to \$3.45 in July 2025 [55].

Shrinkflation as a parallel strategy. Beyond visible price increases, competitors employed significant shrinkflation. Cadbury Dairy Milk sharing bars were reduced by 10% (200g→180g) while maintaining the same price [56]. Mondelez’ s Milka Alpine Milk bars shrank from 100g to 90g while the price rose from €1.49 to €1.99 — a court ruled against this practice in Germany [53]. Mars bars were reduced from 62.5g to 51g [57]. Hershey announced in July 2025 that some products would have “a smaller pack size” alongside its double-digit price increase [55].

Margin compression context. Even with aggressive pricing, manufacturers suffered significant margin erosion. Hershey reported its worst profit since 2017 in Q2 2024 [58], with profits plunging 60% overall in 2025 [59]. Mondelez forecast that “unprecedented cocoa cost inflation” would shrink adjusted EPS by approximately 10% in fiscal 2025, with adjusted gross profit margin falling 680 basis points [60, 61].

In this context, Storck’ s 3–4% proposal represents the most conservative pricing action in the industry — well

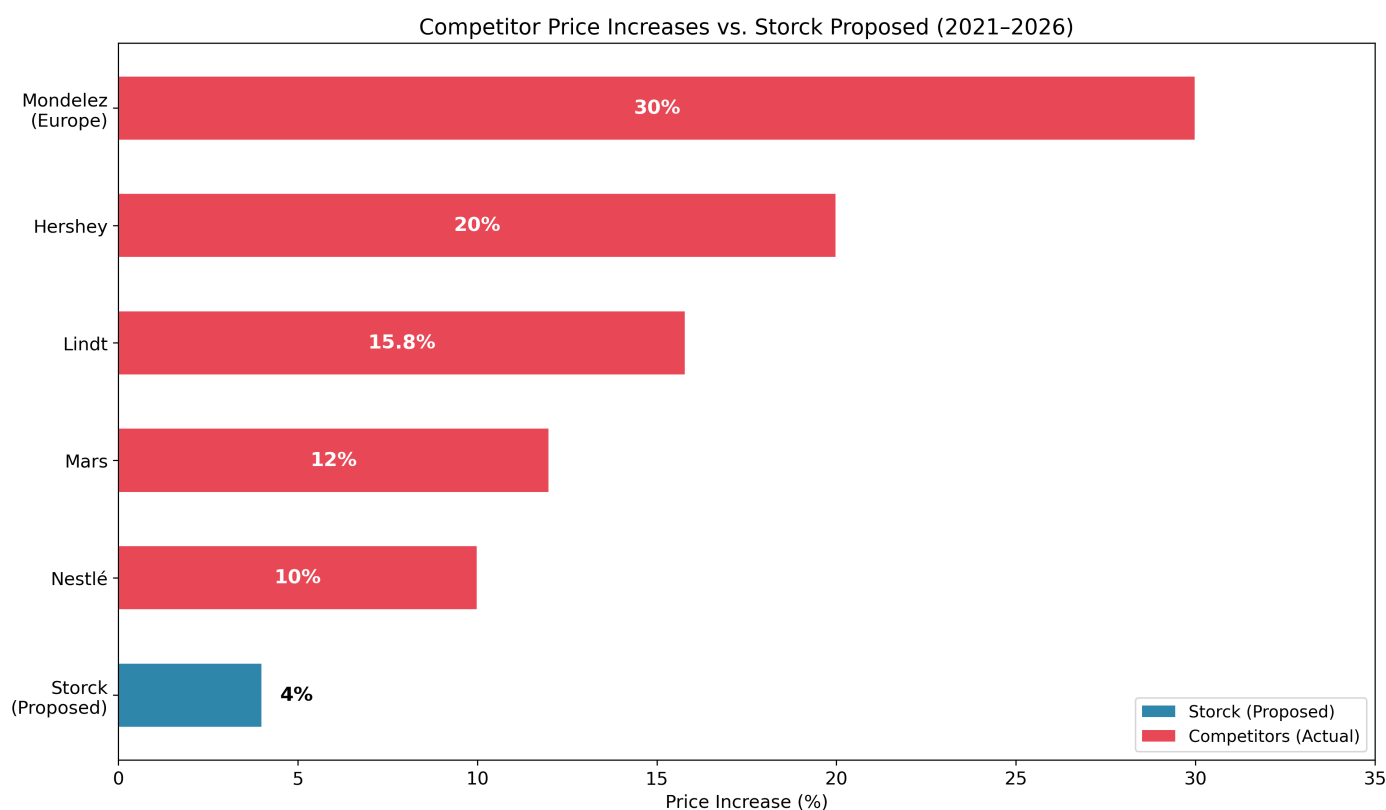


Figure 3: Competitor Price Increases vs Storck

below the 15–30% range implemented by direct competitors.

6 Arguments For the Price Increase

Several compelling factors support Storck’s proposed 3–4% increase as both justified and overdue.

Cocoa remains structurally elevated. Despite the correction from 2024 peaks, cocoa prices at approximately \$3,392–\$3,883/MT in mid-2026 remain above the pre-crisis range of \$2,000–\$3,000 GBP/MT that prevailed for 25 years [4, 3]. J.P. Morgan predicted in August 2025 that prices would remain structurally high [24], and the 2027 outlook ranges from \$4,200–\$6,000/MT, suggesting a “new normal” well above historical baselines [3]. West Africa’s structural vulnerabilities — aging trees, climate change, and disease — persist as ongoing supply risks [3].

Hedging lag means expensive inventory is still being processed. According to Wells Fargo’s David Branch, most chocolate products in early-to-mid 2026 were produced when cocoa was still extremely expensive, and price reductions may not reach shelves until mid-2026 at the earliest [14]. Candy makers buy cocoa months in advance and work through existing inventory and hedges, meaning cost savings from the correction won’t fully materialize until H2 2026 [14].

Broad-based input cost inflation beyond cocoa. The UK Food and Drink Federation reports that food and drink manufacturers expect production costs to rise an average of 4.8% over the next 12 months [62]. More than 70% of European brand owners expect packaging costs to increase [63], and 42% of manufacturers expect labor costs to grow 1–5% while 33% expect increases of 6–10% [64]. The FDF revised its food inflation forecast to at least 9% by end of 2026 [65], and RaboResearch predicts prolonged higher energy prices could push food inflation back up in Europe [66].

Severe margin erosion requires recovery. Mondelez reported gross profit falling by \$387 million driven by soaring cocoa input costs [52]. Hershey’s profits plunged 60% in 2025 [59]. Chocolate-specific inflation was running at 17.2% in the UK as of July 2025 [67]. A 3–4% increase represents only partial recovery of cumulative losses.

Competitive precedent provides market cover. Every major competitor has already raised prices far more aggressively — Mondelez approximately 30% in Europe [5], Hershey in the low double-digits [6], and Lindt confirming further increases for 2025 [68]. Storck’s 3–4% is the most conservative action in the industry, reducing the risk of competitive disadvantage or consumer backlash.

7 Arguments Against the Price Increase

While the justification has merit, several substantial counterarguments challenge the timing and necessity of Storck’ s proposed increase.

Cocoa prices have corrected dramatically. Cocoa futures fell approximately 50% since the start of 2026 as surplus projections replaced deficits [2]. The ICCO revised the 2024/25 balance to a 75,000-tonne surplus, with production at 4.728 million tonnes exceeding grindings of 4.606 million tonnes [3]. West African supply recovery and improved harvest expectations are driving prices lower, with cocoa falling over 10% year-on-year at the start of 2026, extending a broader correction of more than 70% from late-2024 highs [69]. Prices returned to approximately late-2023 levels (~\$3,778/ton) by February 2026, essentially normalizing to pre-crisis levels.

Consumer demand destruction is already underway. Nearly 45% of consumers have cut back on chocolate purchases in response to price increases [13]. US chocolate unit sales fell 5.5% in the 52 weeks ending June 2024 despite dollar sales growing 1.7% [70]. Barry Callebaut, the world’ s largest cocoa processor, reported volumes declining 4.7% in H1 2024/25 [71], while global cocoa grindings declined 7.7% [2]. Mondeľz Europe experienced a 7.5% volume decline alongside 12.6% pricing growth in Q3 2025 [52]. Consumers are approaching the limit of willingness to pay for non-essential items, as acknowledged by Nestl , Mondeľz, and Hershey themselves [72].

Competitive dynamics are shifting toward price cuts. Mondeľz is actively considering price cuts to improve sales [12] and forecasted a subdued 2026 as price hikes turn away cost-conscious shoppers [73]. Critically, private label competitors did NOT match branded price increases, creating a widening price gap that could drive switching [5]. Non-chocolate candy has captured 40.9% of confectionery sales (\$22.5 billion) in 2025, gaining share as younger demographics shift preferences toward gummies and experiential formats [74].

Timing risk: pricing ahead of cost reductions. Wells Fargo’ s David Branch indicated lower cocoa costs would work through production cycles by mid-2026, with price reductions expected to reach US shelves by Halloween [14]. Raising prices while input costs are falling creates reputational risk and exposure to the “greedflation” narrative. Numerator research shows clear consumer price ceilings: only 34% would accept up to \$0.99 more, 30% would tolerate \$1.00–\$1.99 more, and just 18% would stretch to \$2.00–\$2.99 more [13].

Market share erosion. Chocolate is losing share to non-chocolate confectionery, particularly among Gen Z and millennial consumers [74]. A 3–4% increase, while modest in isolation, compounds on top of years of prior increases and risks accelerating the shift toward private label and alternative categories.

8 Conclusion and Negotiation Considerations

Storck’ s proposed 3–4% price increase is supported by legitimate cost pressures — cocoa at approximately \$3,392–\$3,883/MT remains above the pre-crisis range of \$2,000–\$3,000/MT that prevailed for 25 years [4, 3], energy and packaging costs have inflated substantially, and every major competitor has raised prices far more aggressively (Mondeľz ~30% in Europe, Hershey low double-digits) [5, 6]. The proposal is conservative by industry standards.

However, the timing is problematic. Cocoa futures fell approximately 50–70% from their 2024 highs as the ICCO revised the 2024/25 balance to a 75,000-tonne surplus [2, 3]. Consumer demand destruction is already evident, with 45% of consumers cutting back and unit sales declining 3.3–5.5% [70, 13]. Mondeľz is actively considering price cuts [12], and price reductions are expected to reach shelves by mid-2026 [14].

Recommended negotiation position:

Factor	Assessment
Justification strength	Moderate — legitimate but weakening as cocoa corrects [2]
Timing	Unfavorable — costs declining, competitors considering cuts [12, 14]
Magnitude (3–4%)	Conservative vs. industry, but compounds on prior increases
Competitive cover	Strong — Storck has raised less than peers [5, 6, 68]
Consumer risk	Moderate — demand already softening [70, 13]

Table 2: Negotiation Assessment Summary

A balanced approach would be to acknowledge the cost basis while negotiating on timing and structure. Potential

levers include: accepting a lower increase (2–2.5%) with a review clause tied to cocoa price benchmarks; deferring the increase to Q4 2026 when hedging positions will better reflect current lower spot prices [14]; or requesting volume-based rebates that offset the headline increase. The key principle is that any increase should reflect current and forward-looking costs — not legacy peak-period costs that are already unwinding through the supply chain [14, 3].

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